

Empirical Political Slider System

Introduction and Complete Slider Definitions

Political Galaxy Framework

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Introduction to the Empirical Political Slider System

Purpose and Philosophy

The Empirical Political Slider System is a structured framework for analysing political systems, ideologies, and historical periods across multiple independent dimensions. Rather than reducing complex political realities to a single left–right axis or broad ideological labels, the system uses a set of precisely defined, orthogonal sliders. Each slider measures a specific, observable aspect of how power, rights, status, resources, and authority are allocated within a society.

The core purpose of the system is to enable **clear, comparable, and evidence-based analysis** that minimises ambiguity, moral loading, and definitional drift. By breaking political reality into multiple narrow, well-bounded dimensions, the framework allows for more precise mapping of continuity and change over time, as well as more rigorous comparison between different countries, regimes, and ideologies.

Core Principles

The system is built on several foundational principles:

- **Empirical Priority:** Scoring and analysis are based on observable reality — what is actually done in law, policy, and institutional practice — rather than on official rhetoric, self-description, or stated

intentions.

- **Precise and Limited Definitions:** Each slider has a narrowly defined scope. Definitions are deliberately restricted to specific areas of allocation or behaviour and do not expand into adjacent concepts.
- **Orthogonality:** The sliders are designed to measure distinct dimensions. While real-world phenomena may touch multiple sliders, each dimension is kept conceptually and analytically separate to avoid conflation.
- **Non-Moralising Measurement:** The extremes of each slider represent theoretical endpoints rather than moral judgements. The system aims to describe patterns of allocation and organisation, not to assign moral value.
- **Relativism through Clear Anchors:** Each slider includes theoretical extremes (typically scored as 0 and 100) to provide clear reference points, even though real-world cases rarely reach these absolutes.

Methodological Foundations

Observable Allocation and Behaviour

The system focuses on how societies and regimes actually allocate outcomes, rights, responsibilities, status, and authority. This includes both formal rules (laws, constitutions, institutional policies) and observable patterns of enforcement and practice. Rhetorical claims, ideological self-descriptions, and justifications are treated as secondary or irrelevant unless they directly shape allocation mechanisms.

Holistic but Weighted Assessment

When evaluating a period, regime, or political actor, the analysis considers the full range of relevant domains (law, education, employment, institutional governance, etc.). However, not all domains carry equal weight. Core domains — particularly law, institutional rules, and the allocation of significant rights or opportunities — are given primary importance, while secondary domains provide supporting context.

Handling Mixed and Anomalous Cases

Real-world systems are rarely pure. When a case contains both individualist and group-based elements, or both restrictive and permissive policies, the scorer must evaluate the overall pattern using the principle of **primacy** — the predominant, consistent, and impactful direction across the most important domains. Anomalous or contradictory elements are acknowledged but do not override the dominant pattern unless they are themselves significant in scope and effect.

Flexible but Bounded Judgement

The bands on each slider are guidelines rather than rigid mathematical thresholds. They exist to support consistent judgement while allowing for nuance. When a case sits near a boundary or contains genuinely mixed characteristics, the scorer exercises reasoned judgement based on the totality of evidence, with clear justification.

Structure of the System

The framework consists of multiple sliders organised into thematic groups (such as Autonomy, Sovereignty, and various Cultural dimensions). Each slider is treated as an independent axis of analysis. This multi-dimensional structure allows for:

- More accurate representation of political complexity than single-axis models.
- Better identification of continuity and change across different domains.
- Clearer comparison between different countries and time periods.
- Reduced risk of conflating distinct political phenomena.

Working with Individual Sliders

Each slider within the system follows the same general methodological rules but has its own precisely defined scope. When working with a specific slider, the following approach is used:

- The definition is kept narrow and operational.
- Scoring focuses on observable mechanisms of allocation or treatment.
- The slider is analysed independently from other dimensions, even when real-world cases show interaction between them.
- Bands are interpreted with reference to empirical patterns rather than abstract ideals.

Application to Historical and Contemporary Analysis

The system can be applied to both historical periods (divided into coherent eras) and contemporary political actors (such as parties or governments). In both cases, the goal is the same: to map how allocation principles have operated or are operating, using consistent definitions and evidence-based scoring.

When analysing historical periods, eras are segmented according to meaningful shifts in allocation patterns. When analysing current political parties or actors, the focus remains on stated positions, proposed policies, and (where relevant) implemented practices.

Summary

The Empirical Political Slider System provides a disciplined, multi-dimensional approach to political analysis. By prioritising precise definitions, empirical evidence, and orthogonal dimensions, it aims to reduce ambiguity and improve the quality of comparative and historical political research. Each individual slider operates within this shared methodological framework while maintaining its own narrowly defined area of measurement.

Slider Definitions

Core 1 – Autonomy

1A – Personal Autonomy

Measures the observable degree to which the system interferes with or imposes restrictions on the individual's personal autonomy — the range of voluntary actions, speech, choices, thoughts, beliefs, and physiological processes which the individual is permitted to control without systemic prevention or interference. Tracks only systemic invasiveness.

1B – Economic Autonomy

Measures the observable degree to which a system protects or restricts individuals' and private entities' economic autonomy — the range of voluntary economic actions, contracts, property rights, production, trade, investment, and consumption decisions that remain free from state or collective coercion.

Core 2 – Sovereignty

2A – National Sovereignty

Measures the observable degree to which a nation maintains or surrenders control over its own territory, borders, laws, institutions, currency, military, and decision-making authority versus ceding that control to external entities, supranational organisations, or international agreements.

2B – International Sovereignty

Measures the observable degree to which a nation asserts or refrains from interference in the internal affairs of other nations — the range of diplomatic, economic, military, or cultural actions used to influence, pressure, or

control foreign governments, societies, or policies versus strict non-intervention and respect for other nations' sovereignty.

Cultural 1 – Foundation

1A – Foundation

Measures the observable origin of a culture's moral grammar — the degree to which core moral norms derive from transcendent/religious sources versus secular/immanent sources (human reason, empirical utility, social contract, or material conditions).

1B – Dogmatism

Dogmatism measures the observable degree to which a system treats its foundational moral, cultural, and ideological principles as closed — both to internal revision or challenge, and to engagement with or legitimacy for alternative moral frameworks originating outside the in-group. It tracks institutional, legal, educational, and cultural mechanisms that protect core principles from change while rejecting or delegitimizing external alternatives.

Cultural 2 – Identity & Belonging

2A – Individuality

Measures the observable degree to which a system treats individuals as sovereign moral and legal agents versus subordinating them to group identity, collective outcomes, or ascribed categories.

2B – Pride (National Identity)

Measures the observable emotional and cultural stance a system takes toward the nation itself — its history, symbols, founding myths, people, continuity, and collective identity (pride, absence of pride, guilt, or active shame).

Cultural 3 – Group Boundaries

3A – Ethnicity

Measures the observable basis on which a culture defines its core in-group (“us”) — the degree to which group membership is determined primarily by shared ethnicity, ancestry, and descent versus shared ideas, values, behaviours, citizenship, or voluntary adoption.

3B – Exclusivity

Measures the observable permeability of the boundary between “us” and “not us” — the degree of difficulty, cost, cultural resistance, and institutional friction involved in crossing into the in-group.

Cultural 4 – Structure

4A – Social Determinism

Measures the degree to which circumstances of birth (such as race, class, social status) limit, restrict or guide a person's life and the degree to which people are able to improve their status and/or the status of their descendants through their actions.

4B – Equity Lens

Measures the observable framework a system uses to explain differential group outcomes — the degree to which it attributes disparities to systemic oppression (requiring equity interventions) versus individual actions, merit, and personal responsibility.

Cultural 5 – Change

5A – Tradition vs Progress

Measures how the system views traditions and the extent to which it attempts to preserve, modernise, or replace them in favor of new ideals, innovation, adaptation, and future-oriented change.

5B – Gradualism vs Radicalism

Measures the observable pace and intensity with which a system pursues cultural, institutional, and social change — favoring incremental, evolutionary, cautious modifications versus rapid, revolutionary, disruptive transformations.

This document is part of the Political Galaxy Framework for multi-dimensional empirical political analysis.